

“I’ll Eat My Words” - Robert Metcalfe’s failed prediction

Today, the internet is used all over the world. It is a normal part of our daily lives. But in the early days of the internet, some of the computer scientists who worked on it were not so sure it would be useful and safe. Robert Metcalfe is one of those computer scientists.

Robert Metcalfe is famous because he helped create the internet in the 1970s. He is one of the two people who made Ethernet. In 1995, Metcalfe famously predicted that the internet would soon have big problems and stop working. He wrote in the magazine, InfoWorld, that the internet will die by the end of 1996. He added, “if I’m wrong, I’ll eat my words.” This expression, ‘to eat your words’, means to apologize and admit that you are wrong.

Obviously, Metcalfe was wrong. Very wrong. The internet became an important part of society, and now we use it for communication, entertainment, education, business, and many other things. So we might laugh at Metcalfe’s bad prediction. We know that Metcalfe is not stupid, so he must have had a good reason to think that the internet would die. That brings us to the question: Why would an expert computer scientist think the internet will collapse?

To understand Metcalfe’s thinking, we have to understand that at the time, in the late 1980s and 1990s, the internet was growing very fast. More people started to use email, websites, and online services. People went online using phone systems, through dial-up internet services. The technology was still new, and phone systems were not designed to handle that much bandwidth. Connections were slow, and many systems were not ready for so many users.

Metcalfe believed that the physical systems could not handle this rapid growth. He thought it would become too crowded and then crash (Metcalfe, 1995). Metcalfe was a respected engineer and a leader in technology, so many people listened to him. Some people felt worried about the future of the internet. Others were curious to see if his prediction would come true.

But 1996 came and went, and the internet did not die. In fact, the opposite happened. The internet continued to grow stronger. New technologies improved speed, security, and reliability. Companies invested money to build better networks, using new technologies, like fiber optic cables. Engineers solved many problems that Metcalfe worried about (Abbate, 1999). As time passed, the internet became an important part of daily life. Today, billions of people use the internet around the world. It is hard to imagine life without it (Internet Society, 2021).

In 1997, Metcalfe admitted that his prediction was wrong. Of course, he had to ‘eat his words’. At the International World Wide Web Conference that year, he actually printed out his InfoWorld article and ate it in front of a big audience (Computer History Museum, 2010).

This story reminds us that even experts can be wrong. In a way, Metcalfe’s prediction may have encouraged other computer scientists and engineers to improve internet technologies and make sure that the internet does not die. Today, the internet is not perfect. It still has many problems and insecurities, but it is a strong system, a network of networks, and will continue to be an important part of daily life for many decades. It started as a small network, but now it connects the whole world.

Sources

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